Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 18
The Robe



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Wukong and Guanyin flew over the ocean and back to the wide river.

From the sky Guanyin called, “Dragon! Come out of the river at once. The Tang Monk is here!”

The dragon rose from the river and bowed. “Bodhisattva,” he said, “I’m sorry. I didn’t realize the monk had arrived. I was trying to rest. A nasty monkey was . . .” The



dragon stopped talking when he saw Wukong next to Guanyin. “That’s him!”

“This is Sun Wukong,” said Guanyin. “He is traveling with the Tang Monk.”

“The monkey didn’t tell me that,” said the dragon. “I even asked him who he was, and he didn’t answer.”

“I know,” said Guanyin. She shot Wukong a look. “From now on, you must tell people

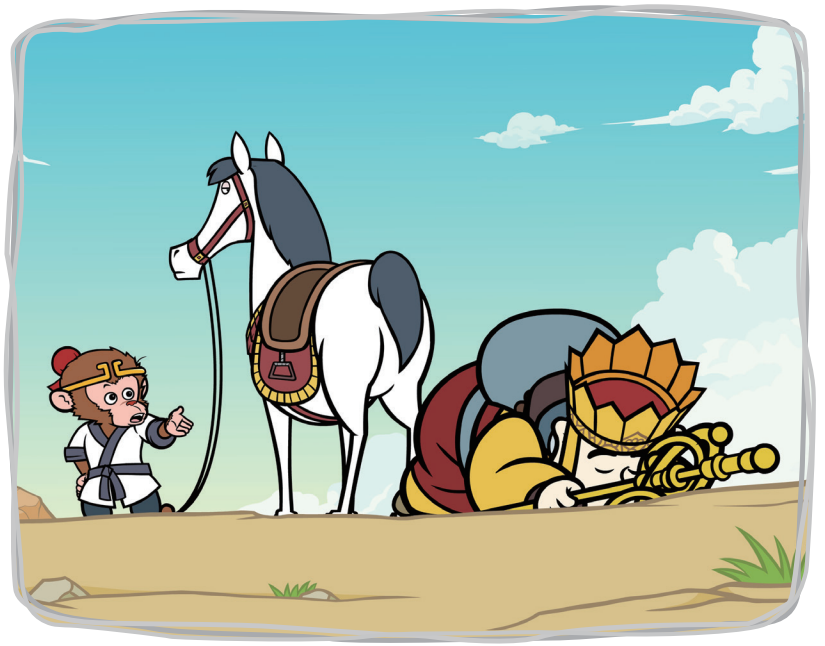


who you are. There are others waiting for you too."

"Okay," said Wukong.

Guanyin looked back at the dragon. "You will carry the Tang Monk to the Western Paradise."

Sparkling light surrounded the dragon. When the light faded, a horse stood where the dragon had been. It looked exactly like



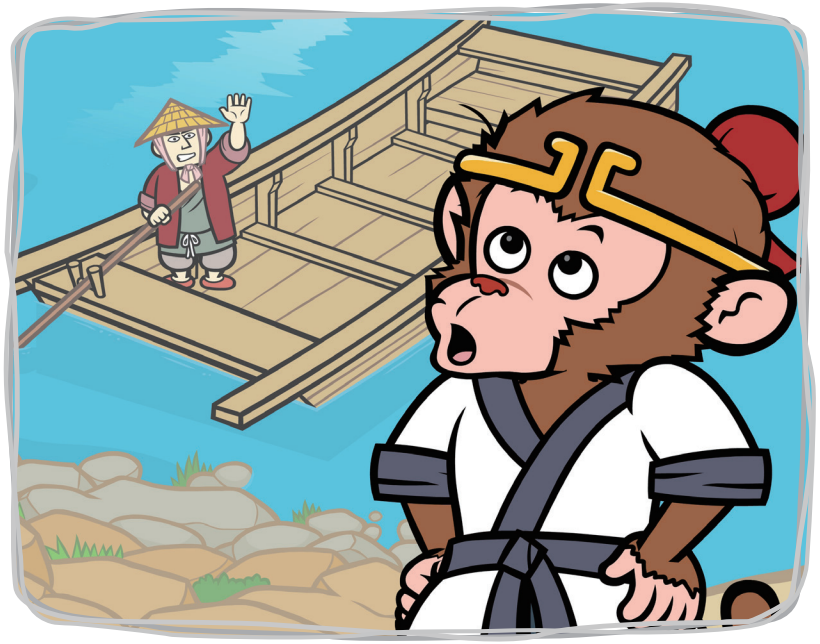
the Tang Monk's horse.

After Guanyin left, Wukong led the horse to the Tang Monk.

"You got the horse back!" said the monk.

"No," said Wukong. "Guanyin was here. She turned the dragon into a horse. He's supposed to come with us."

The Tang Monk fell to his knees and bowed.



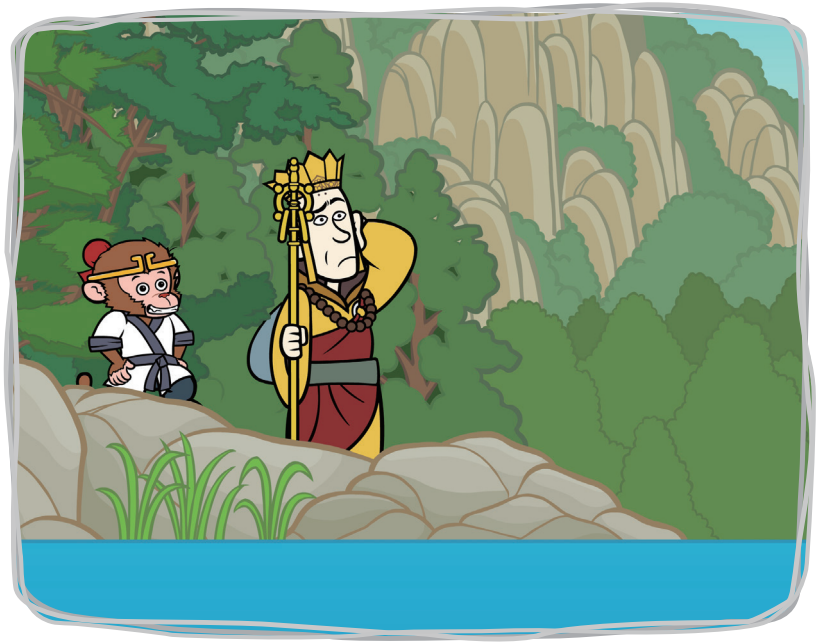
Wukong laughed. “Stand up, Master. The bodhisattva is back on Mount Potalaka by now.”

“Do you need a ride?” called a voice.

Wukong spun around. A boat had arrived next to the shore.

“I will take you across the river,” said the boatman.

The Tang Monk stepped onto the boat,



and Wukong followed with the horse. The boatman didn’t speak as he rowed them across the river.

On the other side of the river, the monkey led the horse onto the shore. The Tang Monk stepped out of the boat. When he turned to thank the boatman, the boat was gone.

Wukong laughed when he saw how confused the monk looked. “He was the



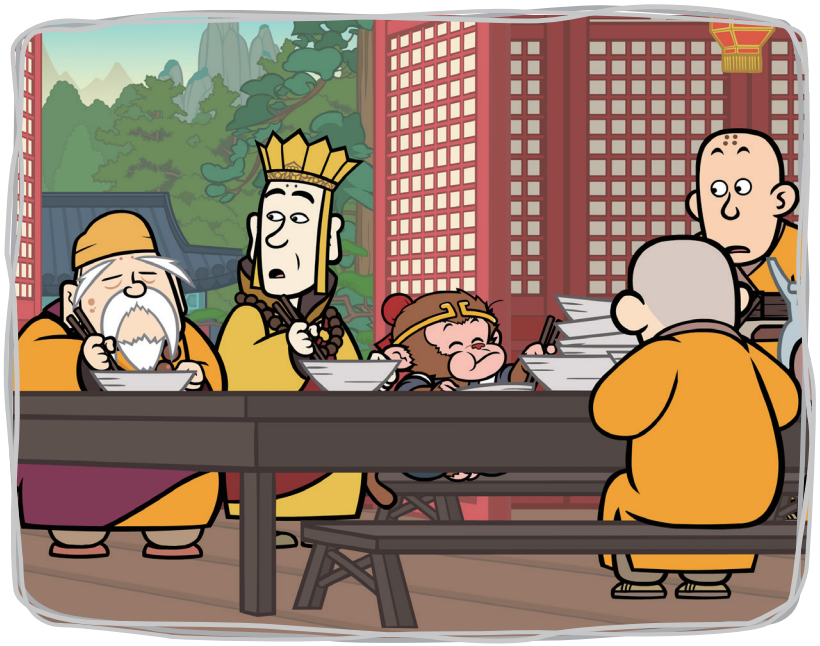
river's spirit," the monkey explained.

The monk and the monkey continued their journey over hills and across plains.

"How long will it take to reach the Western Paradise?" the Tang Monk asked one afternoon.

"A long, long time," said Wukong. "We've barely started our journey."

They walked some more until they



reached a Buddhist monastery.

"Let's stop here for the night," said Wukong. "We're Buddhists. The priests inside will gladly give us some food and a place to sleep."

Later that evening the Tang Monk and Wukong ate a meal with the priests. When the head priest heard where the Tang Monk was going, he was excited.



"You are going to get the True Scriptures," said the priest. "That is quite an honor. How did the bodhisattva choose you?"

"She said that only a true believer could make the journey," said the Tang Monk. "I tried on a robe, and she saw that I was a true believer."

"Do you have the robe with you?" asked the priest.



"Yes," said the Tang Monk. "It's a Buddhist treasure." He reached into his bag and pulled out the robe.

The priest's eyes sparkled. "May I hold it?"

The Tang Monk handed the robe to the priest.

The priest admired it for a moment. "May I borrow it, just for tonight?"



The Tang Monk hesitated. “I guess that would be okay.”

Late that night the priest was awake, gazing at the robe. “I can’t return this robe. I must have it!”